

20. Podcast on Beta (US Influencer)

The Unintended Consequences for Foreign Aid: Case Study of Beta

Host: In 2020, a seemingly small tribal conflict over the control of a water source in a remote corner Beta erupted into violence that quickly spread throughout the entire country and threatened to destabilize the surrounding region. Locals overwhelmingly supported their tribespeople over government forces, and the conflict turned ugly with neighbors often turning on neighbors. International aid organizations were essential for providing many basic needs, and Health for All was lauded for sending their experienced war-time surgeons to assist those hardest hit by the conflict. Fast forward three years, when nine of those surgeons are being held hostage by the very people that they helped treat.

Joining us is Professor E, an expert on the Beta region. Professor, thanks for joining us.

E: It's a pleasure to be here.

Host: You've studied Beta and the surrounding region for much longer than from 2020. What do you think our listeners should know?

E: Well, the most important thing to know is that while we tend to think of Beta as a country: a capital city, a parliament, a president; the region that is now Beta actually consists of three major ethnic groups who have lived in the area for centuries prior to Beta's official statehood in 1964. The capital Beta City lies in the area traditionally occupied by members of group Beta-1. Beta Town, the location of the current hostage crisis, lies in an area contested by members of Beta-2 and Beta-3.

Host: Before we go further, so it is a hostage crisis.

E: In all but name.

Host: Okay, go on.

E: While the areas around Beta City have had significant industry even prior to independence, thanks to the local mining operations, the south and east of the country have remained rural, with many people working as subsistence farmers. Access to water has often been a source of conflict.

Host: Even amongst people of the same tribe.

E: Yes, and that's important. While conflict is often exacerbated by deep distrust between members of Beta-2 and Beta-3, it's these more ordinary human-to-human issues that are often the starting point.

Host: Meanwhile, Beta City seems to have fewer of these issues.

E: As I said, most residents of Beta City are of tribe Beta-1. However, importantly, the surrounding mineral resources and industry around Beta City mean that those in Beta City enjoy a significantly higher standard of living.

Host: And thus fewer conflicts.

E: That's correct. While there are occasional tensions around ritual observances, and protesters from rural areas demanding more resources, the overall higher standard of living – including access to some of the higher quality healthcare in the region, thanks to the revenue that comes from taxing the local mining operations – means that there's less desperation to fuel militias and other destabilizing entities.

Which gets me to my main point: Beta has the means to support its southern and western provinces, it is simply choosing not to do so. The government of Beta, located in Beta City, wants to keep Beta City and the surrounding mining operations stable because that is their

largest source of revenue. With corruption being what it is, many government officials are individually benefitting from the current state of revenue production and investments.

Host: So when Health for All came in to support those injured in the conflict in Beta, they gave the government an excuse to continue business as usual.

E: There's no question that the regional hospital created by Health for All provided higher quality of care during the 2020 conflict than anything that the local government of Beta could have provided, even with the higher standards of care in the capital Beta City. But we have to ask: Why wasn't there a hospital there before? Once the initial tensions eased, why didn't the government step in to take over the operations of the hospital after?

The truth is, for the past three years, Health for All has given the government of Beta a way to ignore the needs of its citizens in the south and east. I think we can all sympathize with the people of Beta Town, who are in desperate need of high quality medical services.

But when international aid organizations go into these kinds of regions, they need to understand the history. It might seem cruel, but they have to insist on local investment before they arrive, no matter how bad the suffering. And once they arrive, they have to train locals to carry on the work – it's not good for the aid organization or the local populations to be perpetually reliant on external support.

Host: Health for All failed to help the people of Beta Town stand on their own feet.

E: And they're paying for it. If they had done this properly, they should have left by the end of 2021. Instead, they hung around for two more years when their expertise could have been used for other conflicts and also to set up health support systems elsewhere. They allowed the people of Beta Town to become reliant on them. They allowed the government of Beta to continue looking the other way.

Host: So what would be your advice now?

E: Let the nine surgeons go. Beta is not doing itself any international favors by holding these people hostage. If they want any international support in future, they can't bite the hand that's feeding them, you know what I mean?

Host: I think our listeners absolutely get what you're saying.

E: And then start doing the actual work. Beta needs to stop only supporting the areas around Beta City and invest in the rural areas like it should have been doing from the start. The current practices are only feeding the rift between Beta-1, Beta-2, and Beta-3. Beta can provide the funds to support the hospital, as well as for any temporary international staff needed for training. Importantly, those staff can be any competent medical professional, they don't need to be war-time surgery experts like the current staff.